

Word family: **serious / seriously / seriousness**

Base word: serious

Related forms: seriously, seriousness

Part of speech: adjective (形容詞) / adverb-related form (相關副詞) / noun-related form (相關名詞)

Your sentence:

> “He can move from a **serious topic** to a witty remark in a heartbeat...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **serious** means **important, weighty, or requiring thoughtful attention rather than being humorous, trivial, or light-hearted**.

The speaker means that Mr. Wong can discuss substantial or thoughtful subjects and then suddenly make a clever joke.

繁體中文： ** **內容重要、較沉重或需要認真思考，不屬於輕鬆、玩笑或瑣碎性質的

**中文翻譯： **

> “He can move from a **serious topic** to a witty remark in a heartbeat...”

「他可以在一瞬間由一個**嚴肅 / 需要認真思考的話題**轉到一句機智的玩笑。」

Here:

serious topic = 內容重要、較沉重或需要認真討論的話題

1. **serious + problem/condition/situation/topic (問題 / 情況 / 話題) — 嚴重的；重要而需認真對待的**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: Important, severe, or significant enough to require careful attention rather than being treated casually.

Practice 1 — Original

> “He can move from a **serious topic** to a witty remark in a heartbeat.”

「他可以在一瞬間由一個**嚴肅而需要認真思考的話題**轉到一句機智的玩笑。」

Practice 2

> “The company is facing a **serious problem**.”

「公司正面對一個**嚴重的問題**。」

Practice 3

> “This is a **serious matter** and should not be ignored.”

「這是一件**重要而嚴重的事情**，不應被忽視。」

serious = 某件事情的重要性、嚴重程度或影響足以令人必須認真處理

Common:

- * serious problem
- * serious issue
- * serious situation
- * serious illness
- * serious injury
- * serious topic
- * serious crime

The exact Chinese changes naturally:

- * serious topic → 嚴肅的話題
- * serious illness → 嚴重疾病
- * serious problem → 嚴重問題

But the broader semantic concept is the same:

> **important/severe enough to demand attention**

Under the Golden Manual, these should not be split merely because the noun changes.

2. **serious** = not joking / meant genuinely (說話 / 態度) — 認真的；不是開玩笑的

Here, **serious** means that someone genuinely means what they say.

Practice 4

> “Are you **serious**, or are you joking?”

「你是****認真的****，還是在開玩笑？」

Practice 5

> “I’m completely ****serious**** about what I just said.”

「我剛才說的話是完全****認真的**，不是在開玩笑******。」

****serious = 說話或態度是真心的、認真的，而不是玩笑、戲弄或故意誇張****

This is genuinely different from:

> “a serious problem”

because here the focus is not ****severity****, but ****sincerity / lack of joking****.

3. ****serious about + goal/person/activity (目標 / 關係 / 活動) — 認真投入；有決心****

****Meaning:**** Strongly committed to something and intending to treat it as important rather than casually.

Practice 6

> “She is ****serious about**** learning Cantonese.”

「她對學廣東話是****非常認真投入的****。」

Practice 7

> “If you are ****serious about**** improving, you need to practise regularly.”

「如果你真的****有決心認真改善****，就需要定期練習。」

****be serious about something = 對某件事情真正重視、有決心投入，不只是隨便試試****

Common:

- * serious about study
- * serious about a career
- * serious about training
- * serious about a relationship

This deserves separation from Meaning 2:

> **I'm serious.**
> = 我不是開玩笑。

versus

> **I'm serious about this project.**
> = 我真的很重視、很投入這個項目。

4. **serious relationship/student/artist** (態度 / 投入程度) — 認真而非隨便的；有高度投入的

This is closely related to Meaning 3.

Practice 8

> “They are now in a **serious relationship**.”

「他們現在是一段**認真而穩定、以長遠發展為前提的感情關係**。」

Practice 9

> “He is a **serious student** of classical music.”

「他是一位對古典音樂**認真鑽研、投入程度很高的學習者**。」

serious + person/activity/relationship = 對某領域、活動或關係投入程度高，不是隨意、表面或短暫的

For database counting, I would **merge this with Meaning 3**, because both share the core concept:

> **genuine commitment / high level of involvement**

5. **serious person/expression/manner** (人物 / 表情 / 態度) — 嚴肅的；不苟言笑的

Here, **serious** describes a person's outward manner or personality.

Practice 10

> “He usually has a very **serious expression**.”

「他平時的表情非常**嚴肅**。」

Practice 11

> “She seems quite **serious** when you first meet her.”

「第一次見她時，她看起來相當**嚴肅、不苟言笑**。」

serious = 表情、語氣或性格較莊重、不輕浮，通常不常開玩笑或表現嬉鬧

This is different from:

> **a serious illness** = 嚴重

and:

> **I'm serious** = 我是認真的

The mental concept here is **solemn manner/personality**.

6. **serious** = requiring substantial skill, effort, or depth (活動 / 研究) — 高水平的；深入的；非業餘玩票的

A common use describes something undertaken at an advanced or committed level.

Practice 12

> “This camera is designed for **serious photography**.”

「這部相機是為**較專業、深入的攝影活動**而設計的。」

Practice 13

> “The book is intended for **serious students** of economics.”

「這本書是為真正**深入鑽研經濟學的學生**而寫的。」

serious = 不是隨便、入門或娛樂性質，而是需要高度投入、知識或技巧的

This overlaps strongly with the **commitment** sense.

For core counting, I would merge it with Meaning 3 rather than treat it as fully separate.

7. **serious + amount/money/damage (程度 / 數量) — 非常大的 ; 相當可觀的**

In informal modern English, **serious** can intensify the size or degree of something.

Practice 14

> “That car costs **serious money**.”

「那部車要花**一大筆錢 / 相當可觀的金額**。」

Practice 15

> “The storm caused **serious damage**.”

「暴風雨造成了**嚴重 / 大量的損害**。」

However, these two examples are not quite identical semantically:

* **serious damage** belongs naturally to Meaning 1: severe/significant.

* **serious money** is a more informal intensifying extension meaning a very large amount.

So I would include **serious money** as a useful informal extension, but I would not necessarily count it as a major independent core meaning unless your database wants conversational intensifiers.

Related form: **seriously**

Seriously inherits several senses from **serious**.

seriously = in an earnest/non-joking way — 認真地

Practice 16

> “Are you **seriously** considering leaving?”

「你真的很在**認真考慮**離開嗎？」

Practice 17

> “He spoke **seriously** about the problem.”

「他很**認真 / 嚴肅地**談論這個問題。」

seriously = severely — 嚴重地

Practice 18

> “Two people were **seriously injured**.”

「有兩人**嚴重受傷**。」

Practice 19

> “The building was **seriously damaged**.”

「這座建築受到**嚴重損毀**。」

seriously? — 真的嗎？

In conversation, **seriously?** can express surprise, disbelief, or irritation.

Practice 20

> “You forgot the tickets again? **Seriously?**”

「你又忘了帶票？**真的嗎？ / 不是吧？**」

Practice 21

> “**Seriously**, you need to stop doing that.”

「**說真的 / 認真說**，你真的需要停止那樣做。」

This is a useful conversational extension.

Related form: **seriousness**

Seriousness can mean severity, importance, or earnestness.

Practice 22

> “They underestimated the **seriousness** of the situation.”

「他們低估了情況的**嚴重性**。」

Practice 23

> “His tone showed the **seriousness** of his intentions.”

「他的語氣顯示出他意圖的**認真程度 / 鄭重性**。」

seriousness = 某件事情的嚴重程度、重要性，或某人態度的認真程度

Important distinction: **serious vs severe**

These overlap with problems, illness, injury, etc.

serious

broader:

> important, worrying, significant, requiring attention

severe

usually emphasizes a **high degree of intensity or harshness**

> severe pain

> severe weather

> severe injury

Compare:

> “a serious problem”

= 問題重要而需要處理

> “severe pain”

= 疼痛程度非常劇烈

Not every **serious** problem is best described as **severe**.

Important distinction: **serious vs important**

important

means something matters or has significant consequences.

serious

often adds a sense of:

- * gravity

- * danger

- * concern

- * non-humorousness

> “an important meeting”

= 重要會議

> “a serious problem”

= 嚴重問題

An important event can still be enjoyable; **serious** often carries a heavier tone.

Important distinction: **serious vs sincere**

serious

can mean:

> not joking / genuinely intended

sincere

means:

> honestly felt or expressed, without pretending

> “I’m serious.”

= 我真的不是開玩笑。

> “I’m sincere.”

= 我的感情 / 說法是真誠的。

They overlap but are not interchangeable in many contexts.

Important distinction: **serious vs solemn**

serious

is broad and can describe:

- * problems
- * intentions
- * people
- * topics
- * commitment

solemn

mainly describes a grave, formal, or deeply serious manner or occasion.

> “a solemn ceremony”

= 莊嚴的儀式

> “a serious student”

cannot naturally become:

> “a solemn student”

with the same meaning.

Important distinction: **serious vs funny**

In your passage:

> **serious topic** ↔ **witty remark**

The contrast is between:

serious = requiring thoughtful or earnest attention

and:

****witty/funny = humorous or amusing****

But ****serious**** does not always mean “sad.”

A serious topic may simply be important or intellectually substantial.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family is:

- * ****serious****
- * ****seriously****
- * ****seriousness****

The family is morphologically small, but semantically rich.

The main distinctions worth preserving are:

- * serious problem → severe/important
- * I'm serious → not joking
- * serious about something → committed
- * serious expression/person → solemn/not playful
- * seriously injured → severely
- * seriously? → really?/are you kidding?

The Golden Manual says that a small family should remain small while genuinely different semantic concepts should still be separated.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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serious — problem/topic/condition	事情的重要性、嚴重程度或影響足以令人必須認真處理，而不能輕率對待
serious — not joking	說話或態度是真心、認真的，而不是玩笑、戲弄或誇張
serious about something	對某件事情真正重視、有決心並願意投入，不只是隨便嘗試
serious relationship/student/activity	投入程度高、並非隨意、表面或短暫；屬於「真正投入」的同一核心概念
serious — manner/personality	表情、語氣或性格較莊重、不輕浮、不苟言笑的

serious money — informal	數量非常大或程度相當可觀的；較口語化	
seriously — earnestly	以認真、不是開玩笑的方式	
seriously — severely	程度嚴重地，例如嚴重受傷或損毀	
seriously?	口語中表示驚訝、不相信或不滿；「真的嗎 / 不是吧」	
seriousness	某件事情的嚴重性、重要性，或某人態度的認真程度	

For your original sentence

> “He can move from a **serious topic** to a witty remark in a heartbeat.”

The exact meaning is:

serious = 內容重要、較沉重或需要認真思考和討論的，而不是輕鬆或玩笑性質的

So:

serious topic = 嚴肅、重要或需要認真思考的話題

For your database, I would count **4 genuinely distinct core meanings** for **serious**:

1. **important/severe enough to require careful attention**
2. **genuine / not joking**
3. **committed and genuinely invested in something**
4. **solemn / not playful in manner or personality**

I would merge **serious student / serious relationship / serious photography** into #3, and treat informal **serious money** as a useful intensifying extension rather than create an unnecessary fifth core sense.